

Some less known facts about Saurabh Kumar

Favourite Book: Collapse by Jared Diamond

Favourite Sports: Tennis and Golf

Favourite Cricketer: David Gower, Kapil Dev, and Sunil Gavaskar

Favourite Actor: Amitabh Bachchan

Favourite Actress: Saira Baanu

Favourite Food: Handi Mutton and Kebabs

Hobbies: Tennis, Golf, and Cooking

of us out there, relates sports to professional and personal life, and has learned to implement the learnings from the four sports he has played keenly. Cricket has taught him the importance of being a team player, tennis and badminton have taught him to be fully focused on the task at hand, and golf has taught him to be patient in life.

His greatest learning in life, however, comes from all the sports, and it is, "Learning to lose," in his own words. One knows the true meaning of winning when one understands and learns what losing is like. "If you learn to lose gracefully, you learn to enjoy the game and how to take decisions on the go," he explains.

Raid on the 150th most rich

The journey of Kumar, from being a respected and looked upon IRS officer to becoming the executive vice chairperson of EESL, has been a phenomenal one. His fellow colleagues often refer to him as "Jack of all trades and master of none." However, a close look at what he has done in life shows on the contrary that he has been a master of everything he has done.

"I joined the tax department in Delhi in 1994. I worked on various things during the next seven-eight years. At the end of eight years, most of the civil servants apply for deputation. This deputation is in one of the ministries. I had also applied for the deputation and got selected as Deputy Secretary, Finance, in the Power Ministry," shares Kumar.

However, there was this incidence that everyone should know before we speak more about Kumar's innings with and after the Power Ministry. The incident started with Kumar and his team doing more than 110 income tax raids in the country in a span of two years.

"An income tax raid has to be coordinated in a way that every official strikes the individual or the institution to be raided at the same time. These raids that we were going to conduct were not simple as we were going to raid the 150th most rich person on the Forbes list at that time. This person's father was known to have lunch at least once a month with the then Prime Minister of India," says Kumar.

Yes, he did raid one of the richest persons back in 2000-01, despite a lot of pressure from many places. This incident once again proved to him why men who are competent and honest at the same time are difficult to find, but those with these qualities really make big in life. Atal Bihari Vajpayee ji was the prime minister (PM) at that time, and despite the PM being a close friend of the father of the person Kumar was seeking a raid warrant for, Vajpayee ji did not shy away from granting him that warrant.

"That day I learned from the prime minister that if you are able to segregate your personal life from your professional life, you become successful. But that is something not usually found out there," explains Kumar.

Kumar and his team went on to conduct raids at this person's premises and seized more than two billion (200 crore) rupees. He was also able to find details about how this person and his company had drawn money out of a public financial institution. The income tax department, in the process of these income tax raids, had to call in CBI. Inspired by the way Kumar worked, one of the directors showed interest in getting Kumar transferred to the CBI from the IRS. However, as Kumar had already applied for deputation with the Power Ministry, he got the role of deputy secretary with the ministry.

"I remember the special director of

CBI calling me and asking me how I can do this and join the Power Ministry and not them? The rule was that if you do not go on deputation then you are not allowed to apply for deputation for next five years, and this is how my professional innings changed from IRS to the Power Ministry," explains Kumar.

He then went on to work with the Power Ministry and the Bureau of Energy Efficiency. Kumar was working with the Power Ministry when he went to Japan to study for masters degree.

United Nations and walking away from EESL

Soon after working with the Power Ministry and BEE, Kumar landed a job with the prestigious United Nations (UN). He was working with the UN in Bangkok when the government of India asked him if he was interested in working with EESL. He requested the government of India for six months before joining EESL. And how was his experience working with the UN?

Landing a job with the United Nations is a dream for many civil servants. The job offers perks that no other job in the world can match. You get a salary that is not only unmatched but is also not taxable, children's education is funded by the UN, you get diplomatic status, a blue passport, and a lot of other things.

"Joining EESL would mean I will have to leave two other jobs and join an organisation that had a turnover of five crore (50 million) rupees and twelve employees back in 2012-13. Yet I left my job with the IRS and with the UN and decided to work with and for EESL," explains Kumar.

Like most of the civil servants, Kumar was also excited about the work that UN did, and he joined the same under UN's environment programme. His starting salary with the UN was 10,000 dollars a month. This salary was also non-taxable. He started working around the 1K Protocol with the UN. For information, this protocol and the work done around the same is one of the most successful programmes ever run by the UN. The programme addressed ozone layer healing and controlling the amount of chloro-fluoro carbons being released in air.